SCOUTING REPORT: ERIC SMITH – ST. PAULI (1. BUNDESLIGA)

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A) Player Information (Source: transfermarkt.de)

Name: Eric Smith

Club: St. Pauli

Nationality: Sweden

Age: 27 (Date of Birth: 08.01.1997)

Position: Central Defender / Central Defensive Midfielder

Height: 1,92 m

Strong foot: Right

Transfermarkt.de link: https://www.transfermarkt.de/eric-smith/profil/spieler/292534

Season Performance:

Season	League / Division	Club	Games	Goals	Assists
22/23	2. Bundesliga	St. Pauli	26	2	2
23/24	2. Bundesliga	St. Pauli	26	1	3
24/25*	1. Bundesliga	St. Pauli	2	0	0

***Current seaso**n (Last Update: 31.08.2024)

Contract end date: 30.06.2025 (There is a one-year extension option both for the player and the team.)

The player was scouted in the following game:

1) 30.08.2024 Union Berlin – St. Pauli: 1-0 / 1. Bundesliga (38 minutes)

B) Report:

Team formation and player's role in team strategy: St. Pauli plays in a 3-5-2 formation, and Smith operates in the central defender position within this 3-5-2 setup. During attacks with buildup phase, he is the main player of the passing network, frequently receiving balls from the keeper and other defenders to play the ball forward. He positions himself in both between the left and right central defenders, and he also moves forward to become the center player W-shaped buildup similar to 4-1-2-3 formations (see Figure 1). If he moves forward, opponent central striker Jordan follows him deep into his midfield. This gives other defenders more room to play the ball forward. He can also change the direction of play from the defensive line under pressure from the opponent's central striker. He asks for the ball often during the build-up.

Figure 1 - St. Pauli's Build Up Options. Eric Smith either stays between the central defenders and goes deep to receive the ball from the keeper or he moves forward to receive the ball in front of the defenders. They used both build up options interchangeably during the game.

St. Pauli struggles with advancing the ball to the opponent half from their half, especially under high pressure from opponents. Many players are prone to mistakes during passing. For this reason, Smith frequently plays long balls behind the opponent's defensive line to carry the ball quickly to the final third and create fast break opportunities. In these situations, central midfielder Metcalfe makes runs to the left wing to get behind opponent right central defender Doekhi, changing St. Pauli's formation to a 3-4-3. He also plays straight long passes to the central forwards if he sees a passing angle through the opposition midfield. In the game against Union Berlin, the aggressive pressing with man-marking in a 5-2-3 formation from Union made it hard for St. Pauli to create these angles. However, he was very effective in taking his team to opponent's half with these successful passes against Heidenheim.

St.Pauli used a 3-4-3 formation while pressing the opponent and switched to 5-3-2 while defending in their own half. During opponent attacks, Smith is responsible for marking the opponent's central striker (Jordan against Union Berlin and Breunig against Heidenheim), challenging the player in aerial duels if the opponent plays long balls. While pressing the opponent, he sometimes moves in front to intercept the ball and prevent the opponent's transition play chance. His awareness in his own penalty area is good, he can intercept the ball by reading the play. His defensive positioning is also good, and he can cover the areas that his defensive partners leave. In defensive duels, he doesn't prefer tackling the opponent and moves together with the player instead. He is not very good at challenging the opponent with body contact.

During St. Pauli's corners and set pieces won in the opponent's final third or in middle third, Smith takes the free kicks and corners. Despite his 1,92m height, he is not used in the opposition box due to his crossing and long ball skills. He also takes shots from free kick opportunities, but his shot against Heidenheim from a free kick was not very effective. When defending set pieces, he is inside the penalty area during opponent's free kicks. He waits at the 6-yard box line in front of his keeper to head the ball during opponent's corners. He is an effective player in aerial duels and marks the opponent's central defenders in these situations.

Figure 2 - St. Pauli's Formation against Union Berlin

Game Notes

He started the game directly with a long ball behind the defense in the first minute. He frequently tried these long balls from the air behind the defense, but these were mostly unsuccessful against Union Berlin. Union was aware that Eric Smith can play dangerous through balls behind the midfield line, so they were defending the midfield with more players than Heidenheim, forcing these long balls behind the defensive line. Smith was successful; however, in changing the direction of play from the center with his positioning in the buildup, helping St. Pauli to carry the ball to the final third. St. Pauli switched between 3-4-3 and 4-1-2-3 to break opposition high pressing with 3 forwards, with Smith moving to central midfield area. As usual, he was the set piece taker of the team, his long ball from a set piece in 13th minute created a chance for St. Pauli.

During defending, he didn't have problems in clearing opponent's crosses and passes into the defensive area. His switching between defensive midfielder and central defender sometimes caused problems, for example in Minute 6 when St. Pauli lost the ball when he was in front of the defensive line. He ran back to mark his opponent, but Union managed to create a shot in this situation. He was defending opponent central striker Jordan, who is a strong muscular player who is also effective in the air. He sometimes had problems in aerial duels against Jordan, but not inside his box, more in the middle third. When he had to cover his defenders and mark fast players like Vertessen and Hollerbach, he wasn't very quick in his reactions. He gave a corner to Union in the 14th minute in such a situation.

He was injured and had to come off at the 38. minute of the game. The injury was not the result of a defensive duel.

Extra: Notes on Eric Smith's Injury

An article in Kicker.de on Smith's injury states the following: *"Chief defender Eric Smith had to come off early once again with problems in his sore spot, the adductors. 'At first I thought it was a torn fiber,' Blessin revealed, but explained on the DAZN microphone: 'He was able to stretch. I hope it's just a pulled muscle and Eric won't be out for longer.' A forced break for the Swede would be the next setback for St. Pauli."* Looking back to his past games, he also had an injury on March 1st, 2024, against Schalke 04 and he had to leave the pitch in the 12th minute of the game. It should also be noted that despite being one of the main players in the starting lineup, he did not exceed 26 games in his last 2 seasons. **All these hints point to the fact that his fitness must comprehensively be investigated should the club decide to invest on this player.**

Assessment

Eric Smith is a ball playing defender, and he can be a very good addition to the passing network for buildup play. In general, he is very effective in carrying his team forward with successful long passes, even against high pressing teams. Despite his 1.92m height, the fact that he uses set-pieces and corners instead of going inside the penalty area is a sign of the quality of his ball playing quality. He can carry the ball to the final third with long balls and through balls behind the defensive lines, he can make a significant contribution by feeding players like Gedson and Rafa running behind the defensive line.

His dedication to defensive tactics and his awareness is good. He is also good at marking target man type of players, but he can have problems in defending players with acceleration as he can't react quickly to players with dribbling skills. He can have problems in teams defending with a high defensive line. He doesn't like body contact and tackles. He doesn't make moves to disrupt his opponent often in one-on-ones unless he has to. His fitness in general is a question mark as well, as he didn't play for 30 games in a season (please check injury notes).

For the current Beşiktaş squad, he will not be a direct addition to the starting lineup as Gabriel Paulista's defensive skills in marking the opponent, defensive awareness and defending transition plays from opponents are better than Eric Smith. He can; however, provide depth to the squad and he can bring tactical versatility to the current squad. He can play as a central defender in defensive lines with 3 players, as well as a right central defender in defensive lines with 4 players. He is also a very good central defensive midfielder and a good addition to increase the quality of a passing network. If he joins the squad, he will be the central defender with best passing skills. This tactical versatility is very much needed in Europa League games, as our current defender rotation doesn't include a player with this sort of tactical versatility, and with Necip having a long-term injury, we don't have enough central defenders in our current squad.